Social Media: Benefits and Risks

Introduction

Social media refers to websites and apps that let people create, share and interact with content and connect with others online. Popular platforms include Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, WhatsApp, X (formerly Twitter), LinkedIn, Snapchat, Telegram and Reddit. The first social networking site, SixDegrees, started in 1997, and Facebook was launched in 2004, YouTube in 2005, Twitter in 2006, WhatsApp in 2009 and Instagram in 2010. India is one of the largest markets for most platforms, with several hundred million social media users, and WhatsApp, YouTube and Instagram have huge audiences, particularly among young people. The Indian government banned TikTok and many other Chinese apps in June 2020. Social media is a powerful tool, with great benefits, but it also carries risks, especially for students and teenagers.

Benefits of Social Media

Social media helps people to stay connected with family and friends across the world, to share ideas and creativity, and to learn: YouTube has lessons on almost every subject, and professional networks like LinkedIn help in finding jobs and building careers. It is useful for businesses, helping small entrepreneurs, artisans and home businesses to reach customers cheaply. It gives a voice to ordinary people and supports social causes, awareness and quick sharing of news in emergencies, such as during the Chennai floods of 2015, when people used social media to coordinate rescue and relief. In January 2017, the Jallikattu protests in Tamil Nadu were largely organised by young people through social media. Creators can earn money, and communities form around shared interests.

What Is a Digital Footprint?

A digital footprint is the trail of data that you leave behind when you use the internet. It includes everything you do online: posts, photos, comments, likes, searches, purchases, emails, app downloads and location data. There are two kinds. An active digital footprint is the data you deliberately share, such as social media posts, comments, filling in forms and sending emails. A passive digital footprint is data collected without your active involvement, such as your IP address, browsing history, cookies, location tracking, device information and the data collected by apps and advertisers. A digital footprint is long-lasting and hard to erase, as content can be copied, screenshotted and archived even if deleted. Colleges, employers and recruiters often check social media profiles, so inappropriate posts can affect admissions and job opportunities, and criminals may use the information for scams and identity theft. A positive digital footprint, with professional, respectful and useful content, can help your reputation. The advice is: "think before you post", and you should regularly search your own name, review privacy settings, delete old accounts, and limit what you share.

How Do Social Media Algorithms Decide What You See?

A social media algorithm is a set of rules and machine learning models that decides which posts, videos and ads appear in your feed and in what order. Instead of showing posts in time order, platforms rank content by predicting what you are most likely to engage with, so that you spend more time on the platform. The factors include your past behaviour (what you liked, shared, commented on, saved and how long you watched or paused on a video), the accounts you follow and interact with, the type of content (video, image, text), how popular the post is, how recent it is, the relationship with the poster, your interests, location and the device used, and what similar users enjoy. Each platform has its own algorithm: YouTube's recommendation system looks heavily at watch time and clicks, and Instagram and TikTok-style apps focus on watch time, shares and saves. Advertisers also pay to target specific groups. The result is that your feed is personalised, which is convenient, but it can also create filter bubbles or echo chambers, in which you mostly see content that agrees with your views, spread misinformation and extreme content that attracts a lot of engagement, and encourage endless scrolling. You can influence your feed by choosing what to follow, using "not interested" options and taking breaks.

Risks of Social Media

The main risks are as follows. Cyberbullying and online harassment can seriously hurt mental health. Excessive use can lead to addiction, poor sleep, reduced concentration and lower academic performance, and comparing oneself with edited and filtered images can lower self-esteem and cause anxiety, in particular for teenagers. Misinformation, fake news and deepfakes spread quickly. Privacy risks include data collection, tracking and data breaches. Scams such as fake job offers, lottery messages, loan apps, romance scams and phishing are common. Contact with strangers can lead to grooming and exploitation, and sharing personal details may lead to identity theft or stalking. Peer pressure and the fear of missing out (FOMO) are other issues. Many countries are now restricting access for children: Australia passed a law that bans social media accounts for children under 16, which came into effect in December 2025.

Name Three Ways to Stay Safe Online

Three important ways to stay safe online are to protect your accounts, protect your privacy and think critically. First, use strong, unique passwords and turn on two-factor authentication for every account; never share your OTP or passwords. Second, set your accounts to private, share limited personal information, such as phone number, address, school or live location, accept friend requests only from people you know, and think twice before posting photographs. Third, think before you click or share: avoid unknown links and attachments, verify news from reliable sources before forwarding it, and be careful with strangers. Other tips include blocking and reporting abusive users, not responding to bullies, saving evidence, telling a trusted adult, limiting screen time, using privacy settings, logging out of shared devices, keeping apps updated and being respectful to others online. In India, cybercrime can be reported at cybercrime.gov.in or by calling the helpline 1930, and Childline 1098 helps children.

Law and Responsibility

India's Information Technology Act, 2000, the IT Rules of 2021 for social media intermediaries, and the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 regulate platforms and data. Posting defamatory or hateful content, impersonation and harassment can be punished by law. Users have a responsibility to be truthful and kind.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include balancing free expression and safety, AI-generated fake content, and addiction by design. Digital literacy education in schools, features such as screen-time controls and age restrictions are growing.

Quick Facts

- A digital footprint is the trail of data you leave online, both active and passive.

- Algorithms rank content by predicted engagement, using your likes, watch time, shares, follows and similar signals.
- Three ways to stay safe: strong passwords with two-factor authentication, strict privacy settings and thinking before clicking or sharing.
- Report cybercrime in India at cybercrime.gov.in or helpline 1930.
- Facebook launched in 2004, YouTube in 2005 and Instagram in 2010.